

LP. 4 - The Churning of the Ocean of Milk

This relief, perhaps the most famous of the 3rd enclosure, is sculpted in the southern wing of the eastern gallery, extending 48.45 metres along its wall. At the centre of the panel is the unfinished figure of Vishnu in front of Mount Mandara which serves as the churning pole, supported by his *avatara*, the tortoise Kurma, who wears a small crown (Fig. 33). Vishnu has four arms; his upper two brandish the discus and the club, while with his lower two he holds the serpent Vasuki. The small figure depicted flying above Mount Mandara, and who seems to be leaning on it with his two hands is problematic: he may either be Indra or another form of Vishnu.

Vishnu directs the churning efforts of the *devas* and *asuras*, who pull the great Vasuki acting as the rope around the post. The *asuras* are depicted identically to the *devas*: only their crested helmets distinguish them from the *devas* wearing conical crowns. Each group is led by three gigantic figures, at the front, middle and end. On the side of the *asuras*, the one holding Vasuki's head is probably Bali or Kalanemi (Fig. 35), or considering the *Ramayana's* influence in this relief, possibly Ravana; the other two figures remain unidentified (Fig. 34). On the side of the *devas*, the figure in the front, closest to Vishnu, has the *rakshasa* hairstyle and is therefore problematic. He could be Vibhishana (renegade brother of Ravana), although Coedès (1911: 116) preferred to interpret him as Shiva or Rahu (Fig. 36). The middle figure with five faces (Fig. 37) may be Brahma (Coedès 1911: 117) but Le Bonheur believed it might be Shiva with an unusual headdress (1995: 45). The last one, holding the tail of Vasuki (Fig. 38), is a mighty crowned monkey, and possibly represents either Sugriva or Hanuman. The slow churning rhythm of the *devas* and *asuras* with one of the heroic-sized figures interspersed regularly among their ranks is an admirable example of rhythmic layout.

Along the top is a register teeming with *apsaras* in graceful flight, while at the bottom is a register depicting marine life – those creatures closest to the churning vortex being cut to pieces. Within the main register, to the right and the left of the lively action, are the reserve armies of the *devas* and of the

asuras. They consist of infantry (bottom two pseudo-registers) and horse-drawn chariots and elephants bearing howdahs (upper two pseudo-registers). For Mannikka (1996: 161) these armies are a crowd of Khmer onlookers who would have gathered at the coronation (*Indrabhisheka*) of the king, to watch the enactment of the scene of the churning.

The textual sources for this episode can be found in the *Mahabharata* (I, chapters 15-17), the *Ramayana* (Book I, chapter 45) and the *Bhagavata Purana*. They differ in the description of the products of the churning, the order in which they appear, and the people attending the event. It is believed here that the Puranic version (Book VIII, chapter 7) adapts best to the sculptural representation. It is summarised below.

At the beginning of the world, the gods (devas) and demons (asuras) were engaged in a thousand year battle to secure amrita, an elixir that would render them immortal and incorruptible. After some time, when they became tired and still had not achieved their goal, they asked the help of Vishnu. He appeared and ordered them to work together, not against each other. Working together, they then commenced the churning of the Ocean of Milk by using Mount Mandara as the pivot and the five-headed naga Vasuki as the rope. However, the mountain suddenly began to sink. Vishnu incarnated as the tortoise Kurma to support the pivoting mountain on his back. Many gods also assisted, including Indra, by keeping the pivot in position. The spinning of Mount Mandara created such a violent whirlpool that the creatures and fish around it were torn to pieces. The Ocean of Milk was churned for another thousand years before producing the much-desired elixir and other treasures, amongst which are the goddess Lakshmi (Sri Devi), the elephant Airavata, the horse Uchchishravas, a wishing tree (Parijata) and the apsaras. The naga Vasuki vomited floods of black venom due to his mishandling by the devas and asuras during the churning. This would have been enough to poison everybody had it not been for Shiva, who drank it all; as a result, his mouth remaining stained forever with a black line.

A bitter fight then broke out between the devas and the asuras for possession of the amrita. Vishnu intervenes

again, this time as the beautiful girl *Mohini*, and regains possession of the *amrita* which he keeps safe from harmful use. Once peace is established, *Indra* is reinstalled as the king of the gods.

This narrative and that of the *Ramayana*, contrary to the *Mahabharata*,⁸ have *Vishnu* in very active role. He appears in the form of the tortoise *Kurma* to support the rotating Mount *Mandara*, and also as the stabiliser of the mountain. He appears simultaneously pulling the snake amongst the *devas* and amongst the *asuras*. He participates also in a gigantic form invisible to all. Furthermore, *Vishnu* infuses *Vasuki* with strength, and in his original form, invigorates the *devas* with power. He appears again later, after the churning was completed, assuming the body of a charming woman (*Mohini*) to regain

the *amrita* stolen by the *Daityas*. But *Vishnu*'s involvement does not end here: once more he had to join battle in the final defeat of the *asuras*.

A peculiarity of this representation of the Churning is the influence of the *Ramayana* on the choice of two of the leading figures on the side of the *devas*. One has the fangs and typical hairstyle of the *rakshasas* in the relief of the Battle of Lanka (LI 8), and is possibly meant to be Rama's *rakshasa* ally *Vibhishana*. The other figure of a monkey king is more likely to be *Sugriva* than *Hanuman*, since this depiction has the same physical features of the powerful monkey fighting *Valin* in the relief of the latter's murder in the southwestern corner pavilion (S 8). The attendance of *Vibhishana* and *Sugriva* at the Churning is not mentioned in the Puranic text, but their inclusion, presumably, was popular



FIG. 34 An unidentified *asura* king.



FIG. 35 The *asura* Bali or Kalanemi.



FIG. 36 Vibhishana (or Shiva?).



FIG. 37 Brahma (or Shiva?).

at that time in the local version of the *Ramayana*. For this reason, it may be that one of the multi-headed and multi-armed heroic figures sculpted on the side of the *asuras* may be Ravana. A similar Ramayanic influence appears in the relief of the same myth sculpted in the northwestern inner gallery of Bayon.

Different identifications of the leaders of both factions have been proposed by Mannikka (1996: 162) on the basis of the type and amount of sunrays the personages receive during the winter and summer solstices. The middle *asura* leader to the left and the middle *deva* leader to the right she interprets as two of the many forms taken by Vishnu to assist in the Churning, in this case his '*asura* form' and '*deva* form'. Mannikka also suggests that the *rakshasa* leader on the *devas* side is Rahu, the demon who infiltrated the *devas* their ranks to drink some of the *amrita*.

Of the small figure in the air over the pole, leaning on or touching it with his two hands, he is believed to be another of Vishnu's manifestations contributing to the churning activity – in this case the stabilisation of Mount Mandara. Finot (1912: 190) believed this to be demonstrated by a passage of the *Bhagavata Purana* (Book 8, chapter 7- sloka 12) in which it is said Vishnu was on Mount Mandara 'holding it with his hands, cherished by the rain of flowers of the gods' (Brahma, Indra, Shiva and others). This, however, may refer also to the large central figure of Vishnu, sculpted half-way up Mount Mandara. Alternatively, this elusive personage could be the god Indra, who we know was watching the churning – and therefore not involved in the action, ready to take for himself, as they were created, the elephant Airavata and the horse Uchchaihshravas. Unfortunately the relief is unfinished and the products of the Churning have not been sculpted; the space where they usually appear is blank. In fact, in other reliefs of the Churning (Angkor Wat south-western corner pavilion S. 1, Banteay Samré), Lakshmi is depicted to the left at the base of the pole and over the tortoise, and Uchchaihshravas to the right. Here, instead, on the right is sketched a dragon cut in two, mirroring the fully sculpted animal on the left which occupies the space that should be reserved for Lakshmi. Even more surprising is the discovery of two outlined figures of a small horse and a tiny elephant over Vishnu's discus. Could it

be that the sculptors did these iconographic alterations due to some controversy over the ranking of the various products of the churning? The possibility that they were later additions cannot be ruled out.

Coedès (1911: 175) noticed that two snakes are depicted in this relief: one at the bottom of the ocean and the other acting as the rope for the churning. He deduced that the sculptors wanted to represent the moment before the Churning when Vasuki was resting at the bottom of the ocean before being pulled out by the *devas* and *asuras* and used as the churning rope. At the centre of the relief Vishnu is also represented twice: first as Kurma supporting Mount Mandara and then as Vishnu *Caturbhuja* (with four arms) in the act of assisting the churning and – at the same time – attempting to balance Mount Mandara. He seems to be suspended in the air in front of Mount Mandara. His left leg is not fully sculpted and below it is a blank area where the products of the churning were to be sculpted, including probably the jar of the *amrita*.

The tortoise is an important figure in Hindu mythology as it is the embodiment of creative power. In Agnicayana rituals the tortoise is placed in the lowest of the altar's five layers (Dange 1997: 246). In general, it is a common feature of Hindu temples where sometimes it is represented simply as a hexagonal figure. It is placed at the centre of the building, or in front of the main shrine of the god, to remind the faithful of its pivotal position in the Churning. In some Balinese temples the whole structure rests on the design of a tortoise, from which the head, four legs and a small tail appear to be poking out. It is a well known fact that in Cambodia, small tortoises cast in metal are often found in the foundation stone of the temple, amongst other objects constituting the 'treasure', and placed in a well dug at the centre of the temple's foundations (Pottier 1997: 17).

The parallelism between the myth of the Churning of the Ocean of Milk and that of the 'Birth of Brahma' from Vishnu's umbilicus while he rests on Ananta has been pointed out by several authors and summarised by Kamaleswar Bhattacharya (1957: VI, 1957: 211). In the Churning, Vishnu as Kurma supporting Mount Mandara corresponds to Vishnu reclining on Ananta in the Cosmic Ocean sustaining Brahma on the lotus. Mount Mandara as the churn-

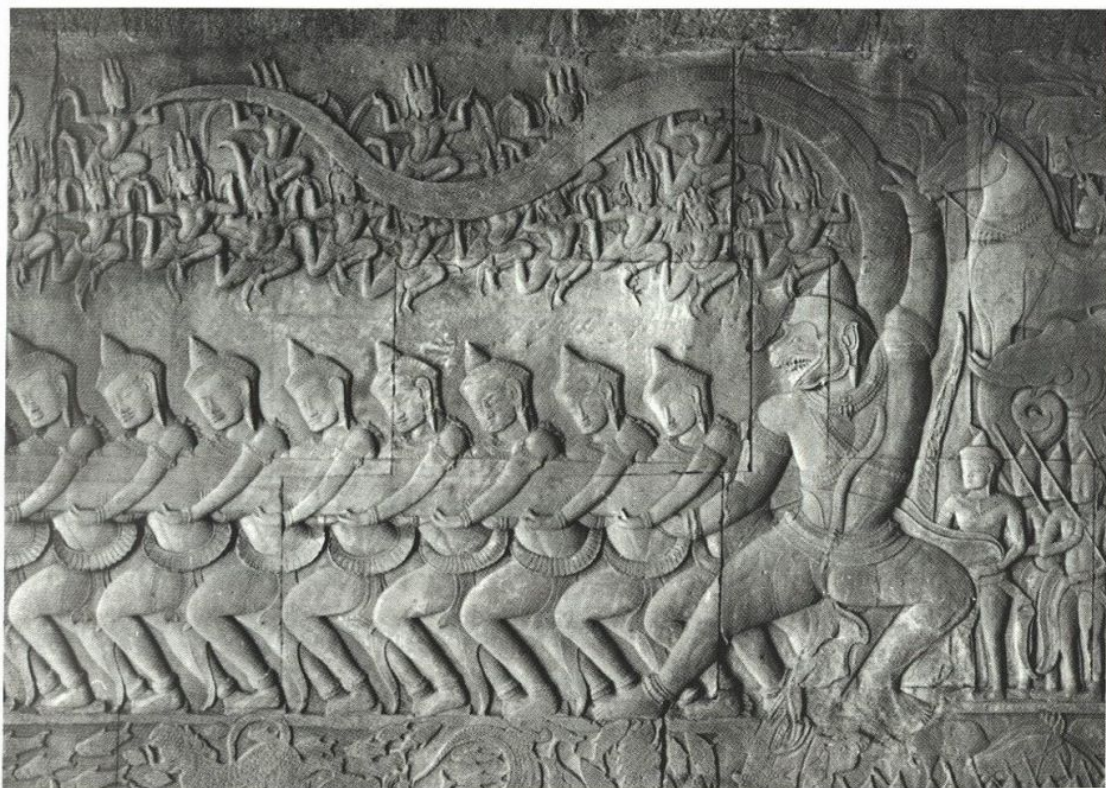


FIG. 38 Hanuman or Sugriva.

ing pole can be correlated with the lotus stem arising from Vishnu's navel to support Brahma. Since both Mandara/Meru and the lotus are symbolic of the centre of the Universe, in both cases we are dealing with the quintessence of the myth of Creation.

Helene Legendre-De Koninck (1992: 47), has stressed that in the present relief of the Churning, the 92 *asuras* have a numerical advantage over the 88 *deva*, and that the general pulling movement seems to be in favour of the *asuras*. This imbalance between the two factions seems to indicate that the *asuras* are on the verge of gaining possession of the *amrita*, threatening to worsen the universal crisis already in place. This requires a new restoration of the order, and the sacrificial incarnation of a god, in a continuous process of creation. Thus the reading of the relief in the context of a sacrificial process is introduced. The panel's three registers are equivalent to three visual layers, of which the lower, filled with animals and vegetal elements, would function as the substitute of the victim. The main, middle register, with the Churning,

has Vishnu at its centre as the officiant, sacrificer and sacrificed (he had to incarnate on earth). Vasuki is the evident sacrificial victim. The highest register depicts the newly created *apsaras* rejoicing in an ideal new order. Mount Meru/Mandara, the cosmic mountain, is the sacrificial post, uniting the three worlds. Kurma, who has provided stability to the process of creation, is placed at the base of the sacrificial site, as in Hindu altars.

Finally, Mannikka (1996: 43) has called attention to commentaries by authors who maintain that the Churning of the Ocean of Milk was symbolically enacted by the Khmer as a tug-of-war exploit during special ceremonies such as the coronation of a king. The latter was symbolic of the reinstallation of Indra as Lord of the Heavens and King of the Gods after having lost this status by killing Vritra who was regarded as a brahmin. To expiate his murder he had to undergo a long period of penance which called for his participation in the Churning. He was eventually re-instated after the battle for the possession of the *amrita*.